been lit in the houses or localities of all these beneficiaries on a single evening.[38]

Even if half of this claim was true, it could only have been made possible through the grassroots reach of its booth-level workers.

Six Presidents, Six Committees and Reservations in the Party's Structure: The New UP Model

In tandem with creating new booth heads in UP, the BJP also instituted a caste- and gender-based reservation system for local-level party posts. We have already seen how, after 2014, the party brought in a new generation of OBCs at the district president level in UP (see Chapter 3). It also created a system of reservations at its lowest levels for women and castes that had traditionally not identified with the party. At the booth level, for example, each president works with a twenty-one-member karyakarini (executive council) of officer-bearers (vice presidents, general secretaries and so on). After 2014, the party began to reserve two seats each for OBCs and SCs and five seats for women among these members. 'This is fixed,' said a district-level leader. 'We have to have that in those twenty-one-member bodies at every level. Whatever level it is, we have to have SC, OBC, women, like this.'[39]

This was such a major change from the BJP's usual catchment of members that, initially, it was difficult to find enough candidates to fill these reserved cadre posts. 'The people weren't there,' a district general secretary explained to me. Many of the early reserved quotas for women, for example, were filled by relatives of local leaders. 'If you want to fill five women, then you make someone's wife, someone's sister and so on. If we had to choose five women, then four we did only to fill the quota but one woman that was genuinely new. That one woman turned into ten—but those ten new ones came from that first one. They came slowly. They did not come together.' The same thing initially happened with Dalits and backward quotas. 'Because five backwards had to be named in each list,' said the leader, 'we put anyone's name down. But we had been talking about it at different places. If we talked to fifty people, then